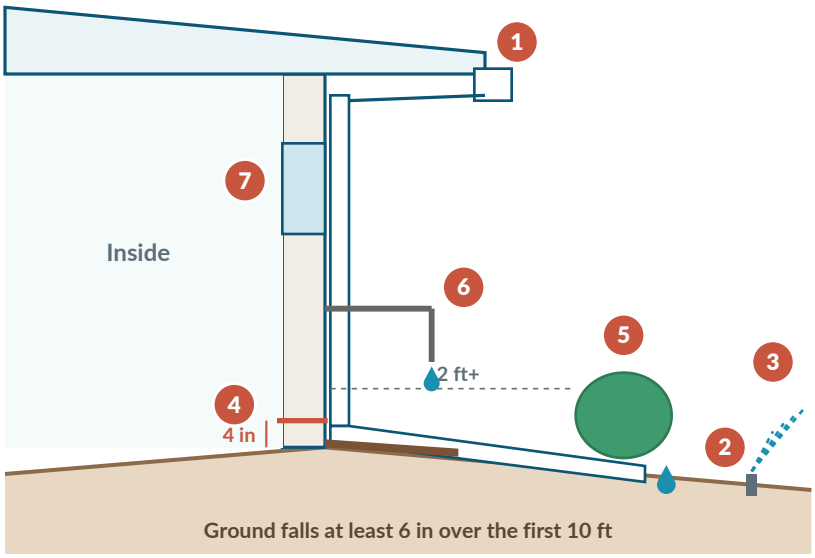
PART 5 OF 11 · LAYER 1: KEEP THE HOUSE DRY

Check the outside of the house

THE SIMPLE VERSION

Rain and sprinkler water should run away from the house, not toward it.
Two times a year, walk around the house with a grown-up. Look for puddles, cracks, and wet spots.

Many of the water problems we investigate start outside: water aimed at the house, water that sits against a wall, or a small gap that lets it in. EPA's moisture guidance starts in the same place: drain rain and irrigation water away from the building.[1] In Florida, heavy landscape irrigation keeps the soil and lower walls around many homes wet much of the time.[2] Walk the house twice a year, after big storms, and if you can, during or just after a heavy rain, when you can see where the water actually goes. Bring a phone for photos, a flashlight, and binoculars, and look at the roof from the ground. Do not climb on it.[3]



1. Gutters clear, not overflowing
2. Downspout empties 5 ft or more away
3. Sprinklers spray away from walls
4. Stucco ends 4 in above soil, 2 in above paving
5. Plants 2 ft out, mulch thin near the wall
6. AC drain line empties away from the house
7. Window sill weep holes open

What good looks like at the base of a Florida wall. Numbers match the checklist on the next page.

Two quick tests you can do

Hidden plumbing leak test: turn off all water use, read your water meter, and read it again two hours later. If the number changed, you probably have a leak.[4] **Window weep test:** pour about a cup of water into the inside of the sill track. It should drain out through the weep holes on the outside. If it does not, clear them gently with a thin wire, or call a window technician.[5]

Outside walk-around checklist

Area	What to look for	What good looks like
1. Roof and gutters	From the ground: missing, lifted, or cracked shingles or tiles, rusted flashing. Gutters that overflow in rain.	Use binoculars and stay off the roof.[3] Gutters run clear in a heavy rain.
2. Downspouts	Downspouts that empty right at the wall, or splash blocks that are missing or turned.	Water empties at least 5 ft from the foundation.[6] No gutters? Watch for a muddy splash line along the drip edge.
3. Sprinklers	Heads that spray walls, windows, doors, or the AC unit. Stains, algae, or peeling paint low on one wall.	Spray aims away from the house, and heads sit at least 12 in from the foundation.[1,7]
4. Base of the stucco	Soil, mulch, or pavers piled up to or over the bottom edge of the stucco. Weep holes painted or caulked shut.	The weep screed sits at least 4 in above soil and 2 in above paving, so trapped water can drain out.[8]
5. Plants and mulch	Shrubs touching the wall. Thick mulch piled against it. Rain barrels or bins stacked at the wall.	Plants at least 2 ft out, mulch under 2 in deep within 12 in of the wall, and a visible gap at the base.[9,10]
6. AC drain and unit	A drain line that empties next to the slab or onto a walkway. A line that stays dry for hours while the AC runs on a hot day.	Condensate goes to an approved spot where it causes no damage, directed away from the house.[10,11] A dry line on a hot day can mean a clog. Call your HVAC company.
7. Windows and sliders	Cracked or missing sealant. Debris or caulk in sill and track weep holes.	Weep holes open and draining. Never caulk over them.[5]
Ground slope	Puddles against the house, or soil and patios that tilt toward it.	Ground falls at least 6 in in the first 10 ft, and patios and walks slope away.[12]
Walls and openings	Cracks, white salt deposits, or rust stains on stucco. Gaps at hose bibs, AC lines, lights, outlets, and shutter anchors.	Openings sealed, and cracks and stains photographed, dated, and watched for growth.
Vents	A dryer flap that does not open when the dryer runs. Lint around the hood. Bath fans that do not vent outside.	Air pushes out of the dryer hood when it runs.[13] Bath and kitchen fans vent outdoors.[14]
Pool, lanai, and screen	Pool decks or lanai slabs that slope toward the house. Screen-enclosure gutters that empty at the wall.	Decks drain away from the house, and enclosure gutters empty away from walls.

Call us if you find

- Stains, bubbling paint, swollen baseboards, or musty odor on the inside of a wall that faces a sprinkler, downspout, or puddle.
- Stucco cracks or rust stains near windows, sliders, or shutter anchors, especially with any stain on the inside.
- Ground that stays soggy or puddled against the slab for a day or more after rain.

Your next step

Print the checklist and do the walk-around this month, then again in six months. Send us photos of anything in the "Watch for" column, and we can help decide whether it needs a closer look.

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